

FREE STUDY AID

The State Board Exam-Day Checklist

Everything to pack, verify, and rehearse before your practical and written cosmetology licensing exams — so exam-day nerves don't cost you the license.

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Before you pack anything: Kit requirements, allowed implements, and permitted supplies are set by your individual state board and testing vendor. Always check your state's official candidate bulletin (PSI, Prometric, or your board's site) for the exact required list — this checklist is a general study aid, not a substitute for it.

01 Practical Kit — Pack & Verify

- ☐ Photo ID matching your exam registration exactly
- ☐ Candidate/admission ticket or confirmation printout
- ☐ Mannequin head meeting your state's specified type — CHECK BULLETIN
- ☐ Mannequin stand / clamp, tested and secure
- ☐ Implements list (shears, combs, brushes, clips, rollers) matching the required inventory — CHECK BULLETIN
- ☐ Sanitation supplies: EPA-registered disinfectant, in original labeled container
- ☐ Disinfectant immersion container of the size/type allowed
- ☐ Single-use supplies (cotton, gloves, neck strips, capes) — unopened where required
- ☐ Timer or watch (if permitted — many centers ban phones)
- ☐ Spray bottle, clean and labeled
- ☐ Extra trash bag / lined receptacle for waste segregation
- ☐ Exact kit list re-checked against this year's candidate bulletin — requirements change

02 Sanitation Musts Examiners Watch For

- ☐ Wash hands before starting and between clients/services
- ☐ Use an EPA-registered disinfectant for all reusable implements
- ☐ Follow full contact-time on the disinfectant label — don't rush it
- ☐ Never place a used implement on an unclean or bare surface
- ☐ Keep a clean-vs-dirty station layout at all times
- ☐ Dispose of single-use items after one use only
- ☐ Know your state's blood-spill/exposure procedure — every state bulletin includes one; review it word for word
- ☐ Wear gloves where the bulletin requires them
- ☐ Verbalize each sanitation step out loud if your practical is scored that way
- ☐ Keep your station organized — visible clutter can cost points

03 Written Exam — Topic Weight (General)

Highest

Infection control & safety

High

Chemistry & hair/skin/nail science

Moderate

Laws, rules & salon business

Exact percentages and content outlines vary by state and testing vendor — confirm the current breakdown in your candidate bulletin. Infection control is consistently the most heavily emphasized area across Milady-aligned programs.

04 Timed Practice-Run Log

Run #	Date	Service Practiced	Time Allowed	Your Time	Sanitation Steps Missed?
1					
2					
3					
4					

05 10 High-Yield Reminders

1. **Verbalize sanitation steps** as you perform them — examiners score what they can observe, not what you know silently.
2. **Never set an implement down** on an unclean or bare countertop, even for a second.
3. Re-read your state's candidate bulletin the night before — kit and rule details change year to year.
4. Arrive with time to spare; late arrival policies at most testing centers are strict and unforgiving.
5. Bring backup single-use supplies in case one is flagged as opened or damaged.
6. Practice your full service under a timer at home — timing pressure is often the real cause of missed steps.
7. Know your state's exposure/blood-spill procedure cold — it appears in every state bulletin for a reason.
8. Keep your work area organized throughout — a messy station reads as a sanitation risk to examiners.
9. Double-check ID and admission paperwork the morning of, not the night before.
10. On the written exam, budget time evenly and flag uncertain questions to revisit rather than stalling.